Mom's Medicaid Application: Your Family's Part of the Paperwork, in Order

Ten actions, with a line for who does each and by when, and a note on where a professional takes over.

The goal: the records for Mom's application are in one place, what's missing or unexplained is written down, and your questions are ready for your Medicaid planner.

Share the list. Put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done. The days are yours to choose; this plan doesn't set any.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Write down your questions for your Medicaid planner about which Medicaid program and application fit Mom's situation, where and how it is submitted, and when to apply.			
2. Put every statement, letter and record you can find in one place, and sort like with like.			
3. Gather the papers about Mom herself: identity and residency papers, Social Security and other income records and, if she is married, her spouse's information.			
4. Gather the papers about what she has: bank statements, investment and retirement statements, insurance information, real-estate papers, and trust or annuity documents if there are any. Note the dates each one covers.			
5. Gather the care and facility paperwork, and whatever you have about any transfers of money or property.			
6. As you go through the statements, mark any deposit, withdrawal, transfer or ownership question you can't explain, with the date and the amount shown. Note it and change nothing.			
7. List the records you haven't found, where you've looked, and who is asking for a copy.			
8. Keep every letter from the Medicaid agency in the folder, write on it the day it arrived, and get a copy to your Medicaid planner.			
9. Ask for a copy of anything that is submitted, the proof of submission and the case or application number, and keep them with the rest.			

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
10. Next to each open question, write who it goes to: your Medicaid planner, an applications specialist, the Medicaid agency or an elder law attorney.			

You're done when

The records you could find are in one folder with their dates noted, the ones you couldn't find are listed, the entries you can't explain are marked, every letter is in the folder, and each open question has a name beside it. What comes after that isn't on this list: confirming the program and the date, completing and reviewing the application, submitting it, replying to the Medicaid agency and following it through to a decision. Those are done with your Medicaid planner and an applications specialist, and they aren't the family's to do alone.

If something won't turn up

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “Not found yet” is a finished line.
- If a bank or an insurance company can't talk with you yet, write down what they said they need. That is an answer you can bring with you.
- If a letter arrives that you don't understand, you don't have to work out what it means. Put it in the folder and show it to your Medicaid planner.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part of the paperwork. It doesn't determine eligibility, complete or approve an application, or stand in for the professional review it prepares you for, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. Rules vary by state; bring those questions to your Medicaid planner.

Ready for the next step?

Your family's part of the paperwork is in order, and you know where it ends. The planning interview is the next step: answer its questions about your family's situation and it gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner.

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